Jewish Identity - What is it all about?

I take a course at Tel-Aviv University titled: “Jewish Identity in Israel and the Diaspora” Recently we were asked to write a critical review on a series of video’s by Avram Infeld known as the 5 legged Table.

http://www.5leggedtable.org/en



I am not asking you to view the video’s on this web sites (each clip 2 minutes or so) I could only recommend you do so if Jewish identity is something that is on your mind.

What I am asking you is to review my critical review on this project and offer opinions, questions, challenges, alternatives whatever… If you do great! If you don’t no biggie!

Infeld’s 5 legged table

By his own admission, Infeld agrees that a table does not really need 5 legs to stand on. In fact 3 could do but anything less and you no longer have a table. As one who was born in Israel and brought up on the Zionist ideal I buy into all 5 legs (keep a spare) without hesitation. Infeld’s model is a modern, traditional, spiritual way to think of one’s Jewish identity and as such may well offer a much better model for modern Jewish youth than to follow their parents’ model whatever it may be without a personal commitment. The results of the latter are known: young Jews are assimilating in droves all across the Diaspora. The global village, social networks, post modernism, post Zionism, and other trendy distractions, are only contributing to the acceleration of this frightening phenomenon.

I disagree with Eli Goetlieb who doubts that making collective memory a personal matter, is a key to realizing one’s Jewish identity. Too much focus has been placed on individualism and populism to recognize the increasing diversity of (multi) cultures and societies. Without strong roots even the mighty oak will topple in

the wind. The internalization of the meaning of Jewish collective memory to one's being is rightly so the first leg of the table. It therefore follows that as Jews we are part of a family. We don't have to be uniform to be unified, says Infeld, but without being unified , we as a people who share common values and beliefs, will, like many civilization before us , disappear and he who says: "So what?" may chose to leave the family right now.

As a secular, albeit traditional and a Zionist Jew, I struggle like many others with the almighty question: " Is there God?" For me, Infeld offers one of the most original philosophical answers I have heard: "The job is taken!" No man can act as if they were God as long as they are human. The consequences of those who forgot this principle are well documented in world history and surely their acts were inhumane. Infeld is a minimalist he distills the Jewish essence to two simple principles that may well be universally acceptable to all Jews and even to non-Jews. You are not God and you were placed on this earth to make it a better place. It is a personal responsibility not an ideal and it transcends modernity. We Jews are not asking you to become a Jew to join in this commitment you're welcome to join us within your religion and based on your beliefs, but don't force us to join your tribe as we have our own and we like it and do not call us infidels because we do not strictly adhere to what you believe is the absolute truth with no other. We have our own table and we like it this way. Beyond these two commitments and with the rituals of our forefathers and our holiday celebrations to refresh our collective memory as a family we are set as Jews. Remember, unified. Not uniform.

I become somewhat ambivalent when it comes to the 4th and 5th legs of the table. Hebrew is my native tongue and Israel is my home land. So that personally I already carry 2 extra legs to make my table sturdy as a Jew. Should you, who was born Jewish in the Diaspora and elected to retain your Jewish identity study Hebrew and make Aliya? Who am I to tell you as long as you remember that Israel is not another point on the Jewish Diaspora map. It is the essence of it. It is our family's ancestral home and it is there where we made the covenant. You don't have to live here to be a Jew but it is your personal responsibility to see to it that Israel remains strong and secure and may all post Zionists who are berating Israel go find a better place.